Unit 5 — The United States Today

Track G+M · Klasse 7 · Niveau G/M

Learning objectives I

- *I can read a short first-person text about visiting an American city and describe two things that surprised the visitor.*
- *I can choose between will-future and going-to depending on the situation.*
- *I can use English articles (a / an / the / —) with country names and city names.*

Lead-in I

Maya stepped off the plane in Phoenix, Arizona. She had imagined the United States as a single image: tall buildings, yellow taxis, a song her grandmother liked. The air at the gate of the airport was warm. The air outside the airport was something else — like opening an oven with your face. Her cousin Jorge was waiting in the parking lot in a small white car. The car had been running, with the air conditioning on, for fifteen minutes. ”Welcome to the desert,” he said. ”We don’t sit outside here in July. We move from box to box.”

Reading I

Reading text — *The Sound of the Desert*

The first thing Maya noticed in Phoenix was the sound of the air conditioning. It was everywhere: in the supermarket, in the car, in the hotel lobby. Outside, the heat had a sound too — the steady drone of cicadas in the desert trees. Her cousins said you stop hearing the cicadas after about a week. She did not believe them. By the end of the third day, she realised they were right. The desert had its own kind of silence, and it was full of noises she would not have called noises a week earlier.

Quick comprehension (oral):

- What does Maya notice first? Why?

Reading II

- What did her cousins predict?
- What does the writer mean by ”its own kind of silence”?

Reading III

Language focus — future: *will* vs. *going to*
English uses two main futures with different uses.

Form	Use	Example
will + base verb	spontaneous decision; prediction; promise	*I'll help you.*
be going to + base verb	plan made earlier; visible evidence	*Look at those clouds — it's going to rain.*

In speech, *will* is often heard as the contraction *'ll*.

Reading IV

Visible-evidence rule. When you can already see the cause of the future event, use *going to*: *He's going to fall* (he's already losing balance). Use *will* for general predictions or promises: *I'll be there at six.*

Language focus — articles with proper nouns

Use *the* with:	**No article with:**
countries with *States*, *Kingdom*, *Republic* (*the United States, the United Kingdom, the Czech Republic*)	most countries (*Germany, France, Spain, Brazil*)
oceans, seas, rivers (*the Atlantic, the Mississippi*)	most lakes (*Lake Constance*) — but *the Great Lakes*

Reading V

Use *the* with:	**No article with:**
mountain ranges (*the Alps, the Rockies*) named regions (*the Midwest, the South, the Highlands*)	individual mountains (*Mount Everest*) continents (*Europe, Africa*)

Use *the* with:	**No article with:**
named buildings (*the White House*)	cities (*Phoenix, Berlin, Tokyo*)

Practise I

Niveau G — controlled
A. Will or going to?

1. Look out — that glass _____ (fall)!
2. I _____ (call) you back later, I promise.
3. According to the forecast, it _____ (be) windy tomorrow.

B. Insert *a*, *an*, *the*, or — (no article).

4. Maya is visiting _____ United States.

Practise II

5. She lives in _____ Phoenix.
6. The capital of _____ Germany is Berlin.
7. They want to see _____ Grand Canyon.

Niveau M — productive
C. Build a short prediction with evidence. Use *going to*.

8. (sky full of black clouds) → ___
9. (your phone battery says 1%) → ___

Practise III

10. (your sister is reaching for the cake on the top shelf) → ___

D. Articles in connected text. Fill in.

11. ___ Mississippi is one of ___ longest rivers in ___ world.
12. ___ Rocky Mountains run through ___ western United States.
13. ___ Phoenix is ___ city in ___ desert.

Your turn I

Writing task — *A Place I Would Visit*. Write 100–120 words about an English-speaking country or region you would like to visit. Cover the three points from the class test (”Klassenarbeit”):

- *one fact* you already know,
- *one thing* you imagine the daily life is like,
- *one thing* you would want to find out for yourself.

Your turn II

Use *would* twice and one future with *will* or *going to*.

Sample student response (Niveau M, 118 words)
I would visit New Orleans because of the music. I already know it is a city in the south of the United States, and that it is below sea level in some parts. I imagine the daily life is slower than in big northern cities, with longer evenings on the porch and people who actually talk to each other on the street. I would want to find out whether the music is everywhere all the time or whether the postcards exaggerate. If I save enough money next year, I am going to spend three days there with my aunt, who speaks French and English and used to live two streets from a famous saxophonist.

Reflect I

- I can read a short first-person American text and explain two surprises.
- I can choose between *will* and *going to* with reason.
- I can use *the* / no article correctly with country names.

Further reading / listening I

- BBC News — *US & Canada* section (short articles for upper-Niveau-M readers). https://www.bbc.com/news/world/us_and_canada
- The New York Times — *The Daily* podcast extracts. https://www.nytimes.com/column/the-daily
- VOA Learning English — short news pieces with audio. https://learningenglish.voanews.com